[13] The priest of Zeus, whose temple was just outside the city, brought bulls and
wreaths to the city gates, hoping to offer a sacrifice along with the crowds. [14] But
when the apostles Barnabas and Paul found out about this, they tore their clothes
and rushed into the crowd, shouting, [15] "Men, why are you doing this? We too are
only men, human like you. We are bringing you good news that you should turn
from these worthless things to the living God, who made heaven and earth and sea
and everything in them." [16] In past generations, He let all nations go their own way.
[17] "Yet He has not left Himself without testimony to His goodness: He gives you
rain from heaven and fruitful seasons, filling your hearts with food and gladness."

[18] Even with these words, Paul and Barnabas could hardly stop the crowds from
sacrificing to them.

[19] Then some Jews arrived from Antioch and Iconium and won over the crowds.
They stoned Paul and dragged him outside the city, presuming he was dead. [20] But
after the disciples had gathered around him, he got up and went back into the city.
And the next day he left with Barnabas for Derbe. [21] They preached the gospel
to that city and made many disciples. Then they returned to Lystra, Iconium,
and Antioch, [22] strengthening the souls of the disciples and encouraging them to
continue in the faith. "We must endure many hardships to enter the kingdom of
God," they said. [23] Paul and Barnabas appointed elders for them in each church,
praying and fasting as they entrusted them to the Lord, in whom they had believed.
[24] After passing through Pisidia, they came to Pamphylia. [25] And when they had
spoken the word in Perga, they went down to Attalia. [26] From Attalia they sailed to
Antioch, where they had been commended to the grace of God for the work they
had just completed. [27] When they arrived, they gathered the church together and
reported all that God had done through them, and how He had opened the door
of faith to the Gentiles. [28] And they spent a long time there with the disciples.

15 Then some men came down from Judea and were teaching the brothers,
"Unless you are circumcised according to the custom of Moses, you cannot
be saved." [2] And after engaging these men in sharp debate, Paul and Barnabas
were appointed, along with some other believers, to go up to Jerusalem to see the
apostles and elders about this question. [3] Sent on their way by the church, they
passed through Phoenicia and Samaria, recounting the conversion of the Gentiles
and bringing great joy to all the brothers. [4] On their arrival in Jerusalem, they were
welcomed by the church and apostles and elders, to whom they reported all that
God had done through them. [5] But some believers from the party of the Pharisees
stood up and declared, "The Gentiles must be circumcised and required to obey
the law of Moses." [6] So the apostles and elders met to look into this matter. [7] After
much discussion, Peter got up and said to them, "Brothers, you know that in the
early days God made a choice among you that the Gentiles would hear from my lips
the message of the gospel and believe." [8] And God, who knows the heart, showed
His approval by giving the Holy Spirit to them, just as He did to us. [9] He made no
distinction between us and them, for He cleansed their hearts by faith. [10] Now then,
why do you test God by placing on the necks of the disciples a yoke that neither we
nor our fathers have been able to bear? [11] "On the contrary, we believe it is through
the grace of the Lord Jesus that we are saved, just as they are." [12] The whole assembly
fell silent as they listened to Barnabas and Paul describing the signs and wonders
God had done among the Gentiles through them.

[13] When they had finished speaking, James declared, "Brothers, listen to me!"
[14] Simon has told us how God first visited the Gentiles to take from them a people
to be His own. [15] The words of the prophets agree with this, as it is written: [16] 'After
this I will return and rebuild the fallen tent of David. Its ruins I will rebuild, and I
will restore it,' [17] so that the remnant of men may seek the Lord, and all the Gentiles
who are called by My name, says the Lord who does these things [18] that have been
known for ages.' [19] It is my judgment, therefore, that we should not cause trouble
for the Gentiles who are turning to God. [20] Instead, we should write and tell them
to abstain from food polluted by idols, from sexual immorality, from the meat of
strangled animals, and from blood. [21] "For Moses has been proclaimed in every city
from ancient times and is read in the synagogues on every Sabbath."

[22] Then the apostles and elders, with the whole church, decided to select men
from among them to send to Antioch with Paul and Barnabas. They chose Judas
called Barsabbas and Silas, two leaders among the brothers, [23] and sent them with
this letter: The apostles and the elders, your brothers, To the brothers among the
Gentiles in Antioch, Syria, and Cilicia: Greetings. [24] It has come to our attention
that some went out from us without our authorization and unsettled you,
troubling your minds by what they said. [25] So we all agreed to choose men to send
to you along with our beloved Barnabas and Paul, [26] men who have risked their lives
for the name of our Lord Jesus Christ.

[27] Therefore we are sending Judas and Silas to tell you in person the same things
we are writing. [28] It seemed good to the Holy Spirit and to us not to burden
you with anything beyond these essential requirements: [29] You must abstain from
food sacrificed to idols, from blood, from the meat of strangled animals, and
from sexual immorality. You will do well to avoid these things. Farewell. [30] So
the men were sent off and went down to Antioch, where they assembled the
congregation and delivered the letter. [31] When the people read it, they rejoiced at
its encouraging message. [32] Judas and Silas, who themselves were prophets, said
much to encourage and strengthen the brothers. [33] After spending some time there,
they were sent off by the brothers in peace to return to those who had sent them.
[34] Notwithstanding it pleased Silas to abide there still. [35] But Paul and Barnabas
remained at Antioch, along with many others, teaching and preaching the word of
the Lord. [36] Some time later Paul said to Barnabas, "Let us go back and visit the
brothers in every town where we proclaimed the word of the Lord, to see how they
are doing." [37] Barnabas wanted to take John, also called Mark. [38] But Paul thought
it best not to take him, because he had deserted them in Pamphylia and had not
accompanied them in the work. [39] Their disagreement was so sharp that they parted
company. Barnabas took Mark and sailed for Cyprus, [40] but Paul chose Silas and left,
commended by the brothers to the grace of the Lord. [41] And he traveled through
Syria and Cilicia, strengthening the churches.

16 Paul came to Derbe and then to Lystra, where he found a disciple named
Timothy, the son of a believing Jewish woman and a Greek father. [2] The brothers
in Lystra and Iconium spoke well of him. [3] Paul wanted Timothy to accompany
him, so he took him and circumcised him on account of the Jews in that area, for
they all knew that his father was a Greek. [4] As they went from town to town, they
delivered the decisions handed down by the apostles and elders in Jerusalem for
the people to obey. [5] So the churches were strengthened in the faith and grew daily
in numbers. [6] After the Holy Spirit had prevented them from speaking the word
in the province of Asia, they traveled through the region of Phrygia and Galatia.
[7] And when they came to the border of Mysia, they tried to enter Bithynia, but the
Spirit of Jesus would not permit them. [8] So they passed by Mysia and went down
to Troas. [9] During the night, Paul had a vision of a man of Macedonia standing
and pleading with him, "Come over to Macedonia and help us." [10] As soon as Paul
had seen the vision, we got ready to leave for Macedonia, concluding that God
had called us to preach the gospel to them. [11] We sailed from Troas straight to
Samothrace, and the following day on to Neapolis. [12] From there we went to the
Roman colony of Philippi, the leading city of that district of Macedonia. And we
stayed there several days.

[13] On the Sabbath we went outside the city gate along the river, where it was
customary to find a place of prayer. After sitting down, we spoke to the women
who had gathered there. [14] Among those listening was a woman named Lydia, a
dealer in purple cloth from the city of Thyatira, who was a worshiper of God.
The Lord opened her heart to respond to Paul's message. [15] And when she and her
household had been baptized, she urged us, "If you consider me a believer in the
Lord, come and stay at my house." And she persuaded us. [16] One day as we were
going to the place of prayer, we were met by a slave girl with a spirit of divination,
who earned a large income for her masters by fortune-telling. [17] This girl followed
Paul and the rest of us, shouting, "These men are servants of the Most High God,
who are proclaiming to you the way of salvation!" [18] She continued this for many
days. Eventually Paul grew so aggravated that he turned and said to the spirit, "In
the name of Jesus Christ I command you to come out of her!" And the spirit left
her at that very moment. [19] When the girl's owners saw that their hope of making
money was gone, they seized Paul and Silas and dragged them before the authorities
in the marketplace. [20] They brought them to the magistrates and said, "These men
are Jews and are throwing our city into turmoil" [21] "by promoting customs that are
unlawful for us Romans to adopt or practice." [22] The crowd joined in the attack
against Paul and Silas, and the magistrates ordered that they be stripped and beaten
with rods. [23] And after striking them with many blows, they threw them into prison
and ordered the jailer to guard them securely. [24] On receiving this order, he placed
them in the inner cell and fastened their feet in the stocks. [25] About midnight Paul
and Silas were praying and singing hymns to God, and the other prisoners were
listening to them.

[26] Suddenly a strong earthquake shook the foundations of the prison. At once all
the doors flew open and everyone's chains came loose. [27] When the jailer woke up
and saw the prison doors open, he drew his sword and was about to kill himself,
presuming that the prisoners had escaped. [28] But Paul called out in a loud voice,
"Do not harm yourself! We are all here!" [29] Calling for lights, the jailer rushed in
and fell trembling before Paul and Silas. [30] Then he brought them out and asked,
"Sirs, what must I do to be saved?" [31] They replied, "Believe in the Lord Jesus
and you will be saved, you and your household." [32] Then Paul and Silas spoke
the word of the Lord to him and to everyone in his house. [33] At that hour of the
night, the jailer took them and washed their wounds. And without delay, he and
all his household were baptized. [34] Then he brought them into his home and set
a meal before them. So he and all his household rejoiced that they had come to
believe in God. [35] When daylight came, the magistrates sent their officers with the
order: "Release those men." [36] The jailer informed Paul: "The magistrates have sent
orders to release you. Now you may go on your way in peace." [37] But Paul said to
the officers, "They beat us publicly without a trial and threw us into prison, even
though we are Roman citizens. And now do they want to send us away secretly?
Absolutely not! Let them come themselves and escort us out!" [38] So the officers
relayed this message to the magistrates, who were alarmed to hear that Paul and Silas
were Roman citizens. [39] They came to appease them and led them out, requesting

that they leave the city. [40] After Paul and Silas came out of the prison, they went to Lydia's house to see the brothers and encourage them. Then they left the city.

17 When they had passed through Amphipolis and Apollonia, they came to Thessalonica, where there was a Jewish synagogue. [2] As was his custom, Paul went into the synagogue, and on three Sabbaths he reasoned with them from the Scriptures, [3] explaining and proving that the Christ had to suffer and rise from the dead. "This Jesus I am proclaiming to you is the Christ," he declared. [4] Some of the Jews were persuaded and joined Paul and Silas, along with a large number of God-fearing Greeks and quite a few leading women. [5] The Jews, however, became jealous. So they brought in some troublemakers from the marketplace, formed a mob, and sent the city into an uproar. They raided Jason's house in search of Paul and Silas, hoping to bring them out to the people. [6] But when they could not find them, they dragged Jason and some other brothers before the city officials, shouting, "These men who have turned the world upside down have now come here," [7] "and Jason has welcomed them into his home. They are all defying Caesar's decrees, saying that there is another king, named Jesus!" [8] On hearing this, the crowd and city officials were greatly disturbed. [9] And they collected bond from Jason and the others, and then released them. [10] As soon as night had fallen, the brothers sent Paul and Silas away to Berea. On arriving there, they went into the Jewish synagogue.

[11] Now the Bereans were more noble-minded than the Thessalonians, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if these teachings were true. [12] As a result, many of them believed, along with quite a few prominent Greek women and men. [13] But when the Jews from Thessalonica learned that Paul was also proclaiming the word of God in Berea, they went there themselves to incite and agitate the crowds. [14] The brothers immediately sent Paul to the coast, but Silas and Timothy remained in Berea. [15] Those who escorted Paul brought him to Athens and then returned with instructions for Silas and Timothy to join him as soon as possible. [16] While Paul was waiting for them in Athens, he was deeply disturbed in his spirit to see that the city was full of idols.

[17] So he reasoned in the synagogue with the Jews and God-fearing Gentiles, and in the marketplace with those he met each day. [18] Some Epicurean and Stoic philosophers also began to debate with him. Some of them asked, "What is this babbler trying to say?" Others said, "He seems to be advocating foreign gods." They said this because Paul was proclaiming the good news of Jesus and the resurrection. [19] So they took Paul and brought him to the Areopagus, where they asked him, "May we know what this new teaching is that you are presenting?" [20] "For you are bringing some strange notions to our ears, and we want to know what they mean." [21] Now all the Athenians and foreigners who lived there spent their time doing nothing more than hearing and articulating new ideas.

[22] Then Paul stood up in the meeting of the Areopagus and said, "Men of Athens, I see that in every way you are very religious." [23] For as I walked around and examined your objects of worship, I even found an altar with this inscription: TO AN UNKNOWN GOD. Therefore what you worship as something unknown, I now proclaim to you. [24] The God who made the world and everything in it is the Lord of heaven and earth and does not live in temples made by human hands. [25] Nor is He served by human hands, as if He needed anything, because He Himself gives everyone life and breath and everything else. [26] From one man He made every nation of men, that they should inhabit the whole earth; and He determined their appointed times and the boundaries of their lands. [27] God intended that they would seek Him and perhaps reach out for Him and find Him, though He is not far from each one of us. [28] 'For in Him we live and move and have our being.' As some of your own poets have said, 'We are His offspring.' [29] Therefore, being offspring of God, we should not think that the Divine Being is like gold or silver or stone, an image formed by man's skill and imagination. [30] Although God overlooked the ignorance of earlier times, He now commands all people everywhere to repent. [31] "For He has set a day when He will judge the world with justice by the Man He has appointed. He has given proof of this to everyone by raising Him from the dead." [32] When they heard about the resurrection of the dead, some began to mock him, but others said, "We want to hear you again on this topic." [33] At that, Paul left the Areopagus. [34] But some joined him and believed, including Dionysius the Areopagite, a woman named Damaris, and others who were with them.

18 After this, Paul left Athens and went to Corinth. [2] There he found a Jew named Aquila, a native of Pontus, who had recently come from Italy with his wife Priscilla because Claudius had ordered all the Jews to leave Rome. Paul went to visit them, [3] and he stayed and worked with them because they were tentmakers by trade, just as he was. [4] Every Sabbath he reasoned in the synagogue, trying to persuade Jews and Greeks alike. [5] And when Silas and Timothy came down from Macedonia, Paul devoted himself fully to the word, testifying to the Jews that Jesus is the Christ. [6] But when they opposed and insulted him, he shook out his garments and told them, "Your blood be on your own heads! I am innocent of it. From now on I will go to the Gentiles." [7] So Paul left the synagogue and went next door to the house of Titus Justus, a worshiper of God. [8] Crispus, the synagogue leader, and his whole household believed in the Lord. And many of the Corinthians who heard the message believed and were baptized.

[9] One night the Lord spoke to Paul in a vision: "Do not be afraid; keep on speaking; do not be silent." [10] "For I am with you and no one will lay a hand on you, because I have many people in this city." [11] So Paul stayed for a year and a half, teaching the word of God among the Corinthians. [12] While Gallio was proconsul of Achaia, the Jews coordinated an attack on Paul and brought him before the judgment seat. [13] "This man is persuading the people to worship God in ways contrary to the law," they said. [14] But just as Paul was about to speak, Gallio told the Jews, "If this matter involved a wrongdoing or vicious crime, O Jews, it would be reasonable for me to hear your complaint." [15] "But since it is a dispute about words and names and your own law, settle it yourselves. I refuse to be a judge of such things." [16] And he drove them away from the judgment seat.

[17] At this, the crowd seized Sosthenes the synagogue leader and beat him in front of the judgment seat. But none of this was of concern to Gallio.

[18] Paul remained in Corinth for quite some time before saying goodbye to the brothers. He had his head shaved in Cenchrea to keep a vow he had made, and then he sailed for Syria, accompanied by Priscilla and Aquila. [19] When they reached Ephesus, Paul parted ways with Priscilla and Aquila. He himself went into the synagogue there and reasoned with the Jews. [20] When they asked him to stay for a while longer, he declined. [21] But as he left, he said, "I will come back to you if God is willing." And he set sail from Ephesus. [22] When Paul had landed at Caesarea, he went up and greeted the church at Jerusalem. Then he went down to Antioch. [23] After Paul had spent some time in Antioch, he traveled from place to place throughout the region of Galatia and Phrygia, strengthening all the disciples. [24] Meanwhile a Jew named Apollos, a native of Alexandria, came to Ephesus. He was an eloquent man, well versed in the Scriptures. [25] He had been instructed in the way of the Lord and was fervent in spirit. He spoke and taught accurately about Jesus, though he knew only the baptism of John. [26] And he began to speak boldly in the synagogue. When Priscilla and Aquila heard him, they took him in and explained to him the way of God more accurately. [27] When Apollos resolved to cross over to Achaia, the brothers encouraged him and wrote to the disciples there to welcome him. On his arrival, he was a great help to those who by grace had believed. [28] For he powerfully refuted the Jews in public debate, proving from the Scriptures that Jesus is the Christ.

19 While Apollos was at Corinth, Paul passed through the interior and came to Ephesus. There he found some disciples [2] and asked them, "Did you receive the Holy Spirit when you became believers?" "No," they answered, "we have not even heard that there is a Holy Spirit." [3] "Into what, then, were you baptized?" Paul asked. "The baptism of John," they replied. [4] Paul explained: "John's baptism was a baptism of repentance. He told the people to believe in the One coming after him, that is, in Jesus." [5] On hearing this, they were baptized into the name of the Lord Jesus. [6] And when Paul laid his hands on them, the Holy Spirit came upon them, and they spoke in tongues and prophesied. [7] There were about twelve men in all. [8] Then Paul went into the synagogue and spoke boldly there for three months, arguing persuasively about the kingdom of God. [9] But when some of them stubbornly refused to believe and publicly maligned the Way, Paul took his disciples and left the synagogue to conduct daily discussions in the lecture hall of Tyrannus. [10] This continued for two years, so that everyone who lived in the province of Asia, Jews and Greeks alike, heard the word of the Lord. [11] God did extraordinary miracles through the hands of Paul, [12] so that even handkerchiefs and aprons that had touched him were taken to the sick, and the diseases and evil spirits left them.

[13] Now there were some itinerant Jewish exorcists who tried to invoke the name of the Lord Jesus over those with evil spirits. They would say, "I bind you by Jesus, whom Paul proclaims." [14] Seven sons of Sceva, a Jewish chief priest, were doing this. [15] Eventually, one of the evil spirits answered them, "Jesus I know, and I know about Paul, but who are you?" [16] Then the man with the evil spirit jumped on them and overpowered them all. The attack was so violent that they ran out of the house naked and wounded. [17] This became known to all the Jews and Greeks living in Ephesus, and fear came over all of them. So the name of the Lord Jesus was held in high honor. [18] Many who had believed now came forward, confessing and disclosing their deeds. [19] And a number of those who had practiced magic arts brought their books and burned them in front of everyone. When the value of the books was calculated, the total came to fifty thousand drachmas.

[20] So the word of the Lord powerfully continued to spread and prevail. [21] After these things had happened, Paul resolved in the Spirit to go to Jerusalem after he had passed through Macedonia and Achaia. "After I have been there," he said, "I must see Rome as well." [22] He sent two of his helpers, Timothy and Erastus, to Macedonia, while he stayed for a time in the province of Asia. [23] About that time there arose a great disturbance about the Way. [24] It began with a silversmith named Demetrius who made silver shrines of Artemis, bringing much business to the craftsmen. [25] Demetrius assembled the craftsmen, along with the workmen in related trades. "Men," he said, "you know that this business is our source of prosperity." [26] And you can see and hear that not only in Ephesus, but in nearly the whole province of Asia, Paul has persuaded a great number of people to turn away. He says that man-made gods are no gods at all.

[27] "There is danger not only that our business will fall into disrepute, but also that the temple of the great goddess Artemis will be discredited and her majesty deposed —she who is worshiped by all the province of Asia and the whole world." [28] When the men heard this, they were enraged and began shouting, "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!" [29] Soon the whole city was in disarray. They rushed together into the theatre, dragging with them Gaius and Aristarchus, Paul's traveling companions from Macedonia. [30] Paul wanted to go before the assembly, but the disciples would not allow him. [31] Even some of Paul's friends who were officials of the province of Asia sent word to him, begging him not to venture into the theatre. [32] Meanwhile the assembly was in turmoil. Some were shouting one thing and some another, and most of them did not even know why they were there. [33] The Jews in the crowd pushed Alexander forward to explain himself, and he motioned for silence so he could make his defense to the people. [34] But when they realized that he was a Jew, they all shouted in unison for about two hours: "Great is Artemis of the Ephesians!" [35] Finally the city clerk quieted the crowd and declared, "Men of Ephesus, doesn't everyone know that the city of Ephesus is guardian of the temple of the great Artemis and of her image, which fell from heaven?" [36] Since these things are undeniable, you ought to be calm and not do anything rash. [37] For you have brought these men here, though they have neither robbed our temple nor blasphemed our goddess. [38] So if Demetrius and his fellow craftsmen have a complaint against anyone, the courts are open and proconsuls are available. Let them bring charges against one another there. [39] But if you are seeking anything beyond this, it must be settled in a legal assembly. [40] "For we are in jeopardy of being charged with rioting for today's events, and we have no justification to account for this commotion." [41] After he had said this, he dismissed the assembly.

20 When the uproar had ended, Paul sent for the disciples. And after encouraging them, he said goodbye to them and left for Macedonia. [2] After traveling through that area and speaking many words of encouragement, he arrived in Greece, [3] where he stayed three months. And when the Jews formed a plot against him as he was about to sail for Syria, he decided to go back through Macedonia. [4] Paul was accompanied by Sopater son of Pyrrhus from Berea, Aristarchus and Secundus from Thessalonica, Gaius from Derbe, Timothy, and Tychicus and Trophimus from the province of Asia. [5] These men went on ahead and waited for us in Troas. [6] And after the Feast of Unleavened Bread, we sailed from Philippi, and five days later we rejoined them in Troas, where we stayed seven days. [7] On the first day of the week we came together to break bread. Since Paul was ready to leave the next day, he talked to them and kept on speaking until midnight. [8] Now there were many lamps in the upper room where we were gathered. [9] And a certain young man named Eutychus, seated in the window, was sinking into a deep sleep as Paul talked on and on. When he was sound asleep, he fell from the third story and was picked up dead. [10] But Paul went down, threw himself on the young man, and embraced him. "Do not be alarmed!" he said. "He is still alive!" [11] Then Paul went back upstairs, broke bread, and ate. And after speaking until daybreak, he departed.

[12] And the people were greatly relieved to take the boy home alive. [13] We went on ahead to the ship and sailed to Assos, where we were to take Paul aboard. He had arranged this because he was going there on foot. [14] And when he met us at Assos, we took him aboard and went on to Mitylene. [15] Sailing on from there, we arrived the next day opposite Chios. The day after that we arrived at Samos, and on the following day we came to Miletus. [16] Paul had decided to sail past Ephesus to avoid spending time in the province of Asia, because he was in a hurry to reach Jerusalem, if possible, by the day of Pentecost.

[17] From Miletus, Paul sent to Ephesus for the elders of the church. [18] When they came to him, he said, "You know how I lived the whole time I was with you, from the first day I arrived in the province of Asia." [19] I served the Lord with great humility and with tears, especially in the trials that came upon me through the plots of the Jews. [20] I did not shrink back from declaring anything that was helpful to you as I taught you publicly and from house to house, [21] testifying to Jews and Greeks alike about repentance to God and faith in our Lord Jesus Christ. [22] And now, compelled by the Spirit, I am going to Jerusalem, not knowing what will happen to me there. [23] I only know that in town after town the Holy Spirit warns me that chains and afflictions await me. [24] But I consider my life of no value to me, if only I may finish my course and complete the ministry I have received from the Lord Jesus —the ministry of testifying to the good news of God's grace.

[25] Now I know that none of you among whom I have preached the kingdom will see my face again. [26] Therefore I testify to you this day that I am innocent of the blood of all men. [27] For I did not shrink back from declaring to you the whole will of God. [28] Keep watch over yourselves and the entire flock of which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers. Be shepherds of the church of God, which He purchased with His own blood. [29] I know that after my departure, savage wolves will come in among you and will not spare the flock. [30] Even from your own number, men will rise up and distort the truth to draw away disciples after them. [31] Therefore be alert and remember that for three years I never stopped warning each of you night and day with tears. [32] And now I commit you to God and to the word of His grace, which can build you up and give you an inheritance among all who are sanctified. [33] I have not coveted anyone's silver or gold or clothing. [34] You yourselves know that these hands of mine have ministered to my own needs and those of my companions. [35] "In everything, I showed you that by this kind of hard work we must help the weak, remembering the words of the Lord Jesus Himself: 'It is more blessed to give than to receive.'" [36] When Paul had said this, he knelt down with all of them and prayed. [37] They all wept openly as they embraced Paul and kissed him. [38] They were especially grieved by his statement that they would never see his face again. Then they accompanied him to the ship.

21 After we had torn ourselves away from them, we sailed directly to Cos, and the next day on to Rhodes, and from there to Patara. [2] Finding a ship crossing over to Phoenicia, we boarded it and set sail. [3] After sighting Cyprus and passing south of it, we sailed on to Syria and landed at Tyre, where the ship was to unload its cargo. [4] We sought out the disciples in Tyre and stayed with them seven days. Through the Spirit they kept telling Paul not to go up to Jerusalem. [5] But when our time there had ended, we set out on our journey. All the disciples, with their wives and children, accompanied us out of the city and knelt down on the beach to pray with us. [6] And after we had said our farewells, we went aboard the ship, and they returned home. [7] When we had finished our voyage from Tyre, we landed at Ptolemais, where we greeted the brothers and stayed with them for a day. [8] Leaving the next day, we went on to Caesarea and stayed at the home of Philip the evangelist, who was one of the Seven. [9] He had four unmarried daughters who prophesied. [10] After we had been there several days, a prophet named Agabus came down from Judea. [11] Coming over to us, he took Paul's belt, bound his own feet and hands, and said, "The Holy Spirit says: 'In this way the Jews of Jerusalem will bind the owner of this belt and hand him over to the Gentiles.'" [12] When we heard this, we and the people there pleaded with Paul not to go up to Jerusalem.

[13] Then Paul answered, "Why are you weeping and breaking my heart? I am ready not only to be bound, but also to die in Jerusalem for the name of the Lord Jesus." [14] When he would not be dissuaded, we fell silent and said, "The Lord's will be done." [15] After these days, we packed up and went on to Jerusalem. [16] Some of the disciples from Caesarea accompanied us, and they took us to stay at the home of Mnason the Cypriot, an early disciple. [17] When we arrived in Jerusalem, the brothers welcomed us joyfully. [18] The next day Paul went in with us to see James, and all the elders were present. [19] Paul greeted them and recounted one by one the things that God had done among the Gentiles through his ministry. [20] When they heard this, they glorified God. Then they said to Paul, "You see, brother, how many thousands of Jews have believed, and all of them are zealous for the law." [21] But they are under the impression that you teach all the Jews who live among the Gentiles to forsake Moses, telling them not to circumcise their children or observe our customs. [22] What then should we do? They will certainly hear that you have come. [23] Therefore do what we advise you. There are four men with us who have taken a vow. [24] Take these men, purify yourself along with them, and pay their expenses so they can have their heads shaved. Then everyone will know that there is no truth to these rumors about you, but that you also live in obedience to the law. [25] "As for the Gentile believers, we have written to them our decision that they must abstain from food sacrificed to idols, from blood, from the meat of strangled animals, and from sexual immorality."

[26] So the next day Paul took the men and purified himself along with them. Then he entered the temple to give notice of the date when their purification would be complete and the offering would be made for each of them. [27] When the seven days were almost over, some Jews from the province of Asia saw Paul at the temple. They stirred up the whole crowd and seized him, [28] crying out, "Men of Israel, help us! This is the man who teaches everywhere against our people and against our law and against this place. Furthermore, he has brought Greeks into the temple and defiled this holy place." [29] For they had previously seen Trophimus the Ephesian with him in the city, and they assumed that Paul had brought him into the temple. [30] The whole city was stirred up, and the people rushed together. They seized Paul and dragged him out of the temple, and at once the gates were shut. [31] While they were trying to kill him, the commander of the Roman regiment received a report that all Jerusalem was in turmoil. [32] Immediately he took some soldiers and centurions and ran down to the crowd. When the people saw the commander and the soldiers, they stopped beating Paul. [33] The commander came up and arrested Paul, ordering that he be bound with two chains. Then he asked who he was and what he had done. [34] Some in the crowd were shouting one thing, and some another. And since the commander could not get at the truth because of the uproar, he ordered that Paul be brought into the barracks. [35] When Paul reached the steps, he had to be carried by the soldiers because of the violence of the mob. [36] For the crowd that followed him kept shouting, "Away with him!" [37] As they were about to take Paul into the barracks, he asked the commander, "May I say something to you?" "Do you speak Greek?" he replied. [38] "Aren't you the Egyptian who incited a rebellion some time ago and led four thousand members of the 'Assassins' into the wilderness?" [39] But Paul answered, "I am a Jew from Tarsus in Cilicia, a citizen of no ordinary city. Now I beg you to allow me to speak to the people." [40] Having received permission, Paul stood on the steps and motioned to the crowd. A great hush came over the crowd, and he addressed them in Hebrew:

22 "Brothers and fathers, listen now to my defense before you." [2] When
they heard him speak to them in Hebrew, they became even more silent. Then
Paul declared, [3] "I am a Jew, born in Tarsus of Cilicia, but raised in this city. I was
educated at the feet of Gamaliel in strict conformity to the law of our fathers. I am
just as zealous for God as any of you here today." [4] I persecuted this Way even to
the death, detaining both men and women and throwing them into prison, [5] as the
high priest and the whole Council can testify about me. I even obtained letters from
them to their brothers in Damascus, and I was on my way to apprehend these people
and bring them to Jerusalem to be punished. [6] About noon as I was approaching
Damascus, suddenly a bright light from heaven flashed around me. [7] I fell to the
ground and heard a voice say to me, 'Saul, Saul, why do you persecute Me?' [8] 'Who
are You, Lord?' I asked. 'I am Jesus of Nazareth, whom you are persecuting,'
He replied. [9] My companions saw the light, but they could not understand the voice
of the One speaking to me.

[10] Then I asked, 'What should I do, Lord?' 'Get up and go into Damascus,' He
told me. 'There you will be told all that you have been appointed to do.' [11] Because
the brilliance of the light had blinded me, my companions led me by the hand
into Damascus. [12] There a man named Ananias, a devout observer of the law who
was highly regarded by all the Jews living there, [13] came and stood beside me.
'Brother Saul,' he said, 'receive your sight.' And at that moment I could see him.

[14] Then he said, 'The God of our fathers has appointed you to know His will, and to
see the Righteous One, and to hear His voice.' [15] You will be His witness to everyone
of what you have seen and heard. [16] And now what are you waiting for? Get up,
be baptized, and wash your sins away, calling on His name.' [17] Later, when I had
returned to Jerusalem and was praying at the temple, I fell into a trance [18] and saw
the Lord saying to me, 'Hurry! Leave Jerusalem quickly, because the people here
will not accept your testimony about Me.' [19] 'Lord,' I answered, 'they know very
well that in one synagogue after another I imprisoned and beat those who believed
in You.'

[20] And when the blood of Your witness Stephen was shed, I stood there giving my
approval and watching over the garments of those who killed him.' [21] "Then He
said to me, 'Go! I will send you far away to the Gentiles.'" [22] The crowd listened
to Paul until he made this statement. Then they lifted up their voices and shouted,
"Rid the earth of him! He is not fit to live!" [23] As they were shouting and throwing
off their cloaks and tossing dust into the air, [24] the commander ordered that Paul
be brought into the barracks. He directed that Paul be flogged and interrogated to
determine the reason for this outcry against him. [25] But as they stretched him out
to strap him down, Paul said to the centurion standing there, "Is it lawful for you
to flog a Roman citizen without a trial?" [26] On hearing this, the centurion went and
reported it to the commander. "What are you going to do?" he said. "This man is
a Roman citizen." [27] The commander went to Paul and asked, "Tell me, are you a
Roman citizen?" "Yes," he answered. [28] "I paid a high price for my citizenship," said
the commander. "But I was born a citizen," Paul replied. [29] Then those who were
about to interrogate Paul stepped back, and the commander himself was alarmed
when he realized that he had put a Roman citizen in chains. [30] The next day the
commander, wanting to learn the real reason Paul was accused by the Jews, released
him and ordered the chief priests and the whole Sanhedrin to assemble. Then he
brought Paul down and had him stand before them.

23 Paul looked directly at the Sanhedrin and said, "Brothers, I have conducted
myself before God in all good conscience to this day." [2] At this, the high priest
Ananias ordered those standing near Paul to strike him on the mouth. [3] Then Paul
said to him, "God will strike you, you whitewashed wall! You sit here to judge
me according to the law, yet you yourself violate the law by commanding that I
be struck." [4] But those standing nearby said, "How dare you insult the high priest
of God!" [5] "Brothers," Paul replied, "I was not aware that he was the high priest,
for it is written: 'Do not speak evil about the ruler of your people.'" [6] Then Paul,
knowing that some of them were Sadducees and others Pharisees, called out in the
Sanhedrin, "Brothers, I am a Pharisee, the son of a Pharisee. It is because of my
hope in the resurrection of the dead that I am on trial." [7] As soon as he had said
this, a dispute broke out between the Pharisees and Sadducees, and the assembly
was divided. [8] For the Sadducees say that there is neither a resurrection, nor angels,
nor spirits, but the Pharisees acknowledge them all. [9] A great clamor arose, and
some scribes from the party of the Pharisees got up and contended sharply, "We
find nothing wrong with this man. What if a spirit or an angel has spoken to him?"
[10] The dispute grew so violent that the commander was afraid they would tear Paul
to pieces. He ordered the soldiers to go down and remove him by force and bring
him into the barracks.

[11] The following night the Lord stood near Paul and said, "Take courage! As you
have testified about Me in Jerusalem, so also you must testify in Rome." [12] When
daylight came, the Jews formed a conspiracy and bound themselves with an oath
not to eat or drink until they had killed Paul. [13] More than forty of them were
involved in this plot. [14] They went to the chief priests and elders and said, "We have
bound ourselves with a solemn oath not to eat anything until we have killed Paul."
[15] "Now then, you and the Sanhedrin petition the commander to bring him down
to you on the pretext of examining his case more carefully. We are ready to kill him
on the way."

[16] But when the son of Paul's sister heard about the plot, he went into the barracks
and told Paul. [17] Then Paul called one of the centurions and said, "Take this young
man to the commander; he has something to tell him." [18] So the centurion took
him to the commander and said, "Paul the prisoner sent and asked me to bring
this young man to you. He has something to tell you." [19] The commander took the
young man by the hand, drew him aside, and asked, "What do you need to tell me?"
[20] He answered, "The Jews have agreed to ask you to bring Paul to the Sanhedrin
tomorrow on the pretext of acquiring more information about him." [21] "Do not
let them persuade you, because more than forty men are waiting to ambush him.
They have bound themselves with an oath not to eat or drink until they have killed
him; they are ready now, awaiting your consent." [22] So the commander dismissed
the young man and instructed him, "Do not tell anyone that you have reported
this to me."

[23] Then he called two of his centurions and said, "Prepare two hundred soldiers,
seventy horsemen, and two hundred spearmen to go to Caesarea in the third hour
of the night." [24] "Provide mounts for Paul to take him safely to Governor Felix."
[25] And he wrote the following letter: [26] Claudius Lysias, To His Excellency,
Governor Felix: Greetings. [27] This man was seized by the Jews, and they were
about to kill him when I came with my troops to rescue him. For I had learned
that he is a Roman citizen, [28] and since I wanted to understand their charges
against him, I brought him down to their Sanhedrin. [29] I found that the accusation
involved questions about their own law, but there was no charge worthy of death
or imprisonment. [30] When I was informed that there was a plot against the man, I
sent him to you at once. I also instructed his accusers to present their case against
him before you. [31] So the soldiers followed their orders and brought Paul by night
to Antipatris. [32] The next day they returned to the barracks and let the horsemen go
on with him. [33] When the horsemen arrived in Caesarea, they delivered the letter to
the governor and presented Paul to him. [34] The governor read the letter and asked
what province Paul was from. Learning that he was from Cilicia, [35] he said, "I will
hear your case when your accusers arrive." Then he ordered that Paul be kept under
guard in Herod's Praetorium.

24 Five days later the high priest Ananias came down with some elders and
a lawyer named Tertullus, who presented to the governor their case against Paul.
[2] When Paul had been called in, Tertullus opened the prosecution: "Because of you,
we have enjoyed a lasting peace, and your foresight has brought improvements to
this nation." [3] In every way and everywhere, most excellent Felix, we acknowledge
this with all gratitude. [4] But in order not to burden you any further, I beg your
indulgence to hear us briefly. [5] We have found this man to be a pestilence, stirring
up dissension among the Jews all over the world. He is a ringleader of the sect of
the Nazarenes, [6] and he even tried to desecrate the temple; so we seized him. [7] But
the chief captain Lysias came upon us, and with great violence took him away out of
our hands, [8] "By examining him yourself, you will be able to learn the truth about
all our charges against him."

[9] The Jews concurred, asserting that these charges were true. [10] When the
governor motioned for Paul to speak, he began his response: "Knowing that you
have been a judge over this nation for many years, I gladly make my defense." [11] You
can verify for yourself that no more than twelve days ago I went up to Jerusalem
to worship. [12] Yet my accusers did not find me debating with anyone in the temple
or riling up a crowd in the synagogues or in the city. [13] Nor can they prove to you
any of their charges against me.

[14] I do confess to you, however, that I worship the God of our fathers according to
the Way, which they call a sect. I believe everything that is laid down by the Law and
written in the Prophets, [15] and I have the same hope in God that they themselves
cherish, that there will be a resurrection of both the righteous and the wicked.
[16] In this hope, I strive always to maintain a clear conscience before God and man.
[17] After several years, then, I returned to Jerusalem to bring alms to my people and
to present offerings.

[18] At the time they found me in the temple, I was ceremonially clean and was
not inciting a crowd or an uproar. But there are some Jews from the province
of Asia [19] who ought to appear before you and bring charges, if they have anything
against me. [20] Otherwise, let these men state for themselves any crime they found
in me when I stood before the Sanhedrin, [21] "unless it was this one thing I called
out as I stood in their presence: 'It is concerning the resurrection of the dead that
I am on trial before you today.'" [22] Then Felix, who was well informed about the
Way, adjourned the hearing and said, "When Lysias the commander comes, I will
decide your case." [23] He ordered the centurion to keep Paul under guard, but to
allow him some freedom and permit his friends to minister to his needs. [24] After
several days, Felix returned with his wife Drusilla, who was a Jewess. He sent for
Paul and listened to him speak about faith in Christ Jesus. [25] As Paul expounded
on righteousness, self-control, and the coming judgment, Felix became frightened
and said, "You may go for now. When I find the time, I will call for you." [26] At the
same time, he was hoping that Paul would offer him a bribe. So he sent for Paul

frequently and talked with him. [27] After two years had passed, Felix was succeeded by Porcius Festus. And wishing to do the Jews a favor, Felix left Paul in prison.

25 Three days after his arrival in the province, Festus went up from Caesarea to Jerusalem, [2] where the chief priests and Jewish leaders presented their case against Paul. They urged Festus [3] to grant them a concession against Paul by summoning him to Jerusalem, because they were preparing an ambush to kill him along the way. [4] But Festus replied, "Paul is being held in Caesarea, and I myself am going there soon." [5] "So if this man has done anything wrong, let some of your leaders come down with me and accuse him there." [6] After spending no more than eight or ten days with them, Festus went down to Caesarea. The next day he sat on the judgment seat and ordered that Paul be brought in. [7] When Paul arrived, the Jews who had come down from Jerusalem stood around him, bringing many serious charges that they could not prove. [8] Then Paul made his defense: "I have committed no offense against the law of the Jews or against the temple or against Caesar."

[9] But Festus, wishing to do the Jews a favor, said to Paul, "Are you willing to go up to Jerusalem to stand trial before me on these charges?" [10] Paul replied, "I am standing before the judgment seat of Caesar, where I ought to be tried. I have done nothing wrong to the Jews, as you yourself know very well." [11] "If, however, I am guilty of anything worthy of death, I do not refuse to die. But if there is no truth to their accusations against me, no one has the right to hand me over to them. I appeal to Caesar!"

[12] Then Festus conferred with his council and replied, "You have appealed to Caesar. To Caesar you will go!" [13] After several days had passed, King Agrippa and Bernice came down to Caesarea to pay their respects to Festus. [14] Since they were staying several days, Festus laid out Paul's case before the king: "There is a certain man whom Felix left in prison." [15] While I was in Jerusalem, the chief priests and elders of the Jews presented their case and requested a judgment against him. [16] I told them that it is not the Roman custom to hand a man over before he has had an opportunity to face his accusers and defend himself against their charges. [17] So when they came here with me, I did not delay. The next day I sat on the judgment seat and ordered that the man be brought in.

[18] But when his accusers rose to speak, they did not charge him with any of the crimes I had expected. [19] They only had some contentions with him regarding their own religion and a certain Jesus who had died, but whom Paul affirmed to be alive. [20] Since I was at a loss as to how to investigate these matters, I asked if he was willing to go to Jerusalem and be tried there on these charges. [21] "But when Paul appealed to be held over for the decision of the Emperor, I ordered that he be held until I could send him to Caesar." [22] Then Agrippa said to Festus, "I would like to hear this man myself." "Tomorrow you will hear him," Festus declared. [23] The next day Agrippa and Bernice came with great pomp and entered the auditorium, along with the commanders and leading men of the city. And Festus ordered that Paul be brought in. [24] Then Festus said, "King Agrippa and all who are present with us, you see this man. The whole Jewish community has petitioned me about him, both here and in Jerusalem, crying out that he ought not to live any longer." [25] But I found he had done nothing worthy of death, and since he has now appealed to the Emperor, I decided to send him. [26] I have nothing definite to write to our sovereign one about him. Therefore I have brought him before all of you, and especially before you, King Agrippa, so that after this inquiry I may have something to write. [27] "For it seems unreasonable to me to send on a prisoner without specifying the charges against him."

26 Agrippa said to Paul, "You have permission to speak for yourself." Then Paul stretched out his hand and began his defense: [2] "King Agrippa, I consider myself fortunate to stand before you today to defend myself against all the accusations of the Jews," [3] especially since you are acquainted with all the Jewish customs and controversies. I beg you, therefore, to listen to me patiently. [4] Surely all the Jews know how I have lived from the earliest days of my youth, among my own people and in Jerusalem. [5] They have known me for a long time and can testify, if they are willing, that I lived as a Pharisee, adhering to the strictest sect of our religion. [6] And now I stand on trial because of my hope in the promise that God made to our fathers, [7] the promise our twelve tribes are hoping to realize as they earnestly serve God day and night. It is because of this hope, O king, that I am accused by the Jews. [8] Why would any of you consider it incredible that God raises the dead? [9] So then, I too was convinced that I ought to do all I could to oppose the name of Jesus of Nazareth.

[10] And that is what I did in Jerusalem. With authority from the chief priests I put many of the saints in prison, and when they were condemned to death, I cast my vote against them. [11] I frequently had them punished in the synagogues, and I tried to make them blaspheme. In my raging fury against them, I even went to foreign cities to persecute them. [12] In this pursuit I was on my way to Damascus with the authority and commission of the chief priests. [13] About noon, O king, as I was on the road, I saw a light from heaven, brighter than the sun, shining around me and my companions.

[14] We all fell to the ground, and I heard a voice say to me in Hebrew, 'Saul, Saul, why do you persecute Me? It is hard for you to kick against the goads.' [15] 'Who are You, Lord?' I asked. 'I am Jesus, whom you are persecuting,' the Lord replied. [16] 'But get up and stand on your feet. For I have appeared to you to appoint you as a servant and as a witness of what you have seen from Me and what I will show you.' [17] I will rescue you from your own people and from the Gentiles. I am sending you to them [18] to open their eyes, so that they may turn from darkness to light and from the power of Satan to God, that they may receive forgiveness of sins and an inheritance among those sanctified by faith in Me.' [19] So then, King Agrippa, I was not disobedient to the heavenly vision. [20] First to those in Damascus and Jerusalem, then to everyone in the region of Judea, and then to the Gentiles, I declared that they should repent and turn to God, performing deeds worthy of their repentance.

[21] For this reason the Jews seized me in the temple courts and tried to kill me. [22] But I have had God's help to this day, and I stand here to testify to small and great alike. I am saying nothing beyond what the prophets and Moses said would happen: [23] "that the Christ would suffer, and as the first to rise from the dead, would proclaim light to our people and to the Gentiles." [24] At this stage of Paul's defense, Festus exclaimed in a loud voice, "You are insane, Paul! Your great learning is driving you to madness!" [25] But Paul answered, "I am not insane, most excellent Festus; I am speaking words of truth and sobriety." [26] For the king knows about these matters, and I can speak freely to him. I am confident that none of this has escaped his notice, because it was not done in a corner. [27] "King Agrippa, do you believe the prophets? I know you do." [28] Then Agrippa said to Paul, "Can you persuade me in such a short time to become a Christian?" [29] "Short time or long," Paul replied, "I wish to God that not only you but all who hear me this day may become what I am, except for these chains." [30] Then the king and the governor rose, along with Bernice and those seated with them. [31] On their way out, they said to one another, "This man has done nothing worthy of death or imprisonment." [32] And Agrippa said to Festus, "This man could have been released if he had not appealed to Caesar."

27 When it was decided that we would sail for Italy, Paul and some other prisoners were handed over to a centurion named Julius, who belonged to the Imperial Regiment. [2] We boarded an Adramyttian ship about to sail for ports along the coast of Asia, and we put out to sea. Aristarchus, a Macedonian from Thessalonica, was with us. [3] The next day we landed at Sidon, and Julius treated Paul with consideration, allowing him to visit his friends and receive their care. [4] After putting out from there, we sailed to the lee of Cyprus because the winds were against us. [5] And when we had sailed across the open sea off the coast of Cilicia and Pamphylia, we came to Myra in Lycia. [6] There the centurion found an Alexandrian ship sailing for Italy and put us on board. [7] After sailing slowly for many days, we arrived off Cnidus. When the wind impeded us, we sailed to the lee of Crete, opposite Salmone. [8] After we had moved along the coast with difficulty, we came to a place called Fair Havens, near the town of Lasea. [9] By now much time had passed, and the voyage had already become dangerous because it was after the Fast. So Paul advised them, [10] "Men, I can see that our voyage will be filled with disaster and great loss, not only to ship and cargo, but to our own lives as well." [11] But contrary to Paul's advice, the centurion was persuaded by the pilot and by the owner of the ship. [12] Since the harbor was unsuitable to winter in, the majority decided to sail on, if somehow they could reach Phoenix to winter there. Phoenix was a harbor in Crete facing both southwest and northwest. [13] When a gentle south wind began to blow, they thought they had their opportunity. So they weighed anchor and sailed along, hugging the coast of Crete.

[14] But it was not long before a cyclone called the Northeaster swept down across the island. [15] Unable to head into the wind, the ship was caught up. So we gave way and let ourselves be driven along. [16] Passing to the lee of a small island called Cauda, we barely managed to secure the lifeboat. [17] After hoisting it up, the crew used ropes to undergird the ship. And fearing that they would run aground on the sandbars of Syrtis, they lowered the sea anchor and were driven along. [18] We were tossed so violently that the next day the men began to jettison the cargo. [19] On the third day, they threw the ship's tackle overboard with their own hands. [20] When neither sun nor stars appeared for many days and the great storm continued to batter us, we abandoned all hope of being saved.

[21] After the men had gone a long time without food, Paul stood up among them and said, "Men, you should have followed my advice not to sail from Crete. Then you would have averted this disaster and loss." [22] But now I urge you to keep up your courage, because you will not experience any loss of life, but only of the ship. [23] For just last night an angel of God, whose I am and whom I serve, stood beside me [24] and said, 'Do not be afraid, Paul; you must stand before Caesar. And look, God has granted you the lives of all who sail with you.' [25] So take courage, men, for I believe God that it will happen just as He told me. [26] "However, we must run aground on some island." [27] On the fourteenth night we were still being driven across the Adriatic Sea. About midnight the sailors sensed they were approaching land. [28] They took soundings and found that the water was twenty fathoms deep. Going a little farther, they took another set of soundings that read fifteen fathoms.

[29] Fearing that we would run aground on the rocks, they dropped four anchors from the stern and prayed for daybreak. [30] Meanwhile, the sailors attempted to escape from the ship. Pretending to lower anchors from the bow, they let the lifeboat down into the sea. [31] But Paul said to the centurion and the soldiers, "Unless these

men remain with the ship, you cannot be saved." [32] So the soldiers cut the ropes to the lifeboat and set it adrift. [33] Right up to daybreak, Paul kept urging them all to eat: "Today is your fourteenth day in constant suspense, without taking any food." [34] "So for your own preservation, I urge you to eat something, because not a single hair of your head will be lost." [35] After he had said this, Paul took bread and gave thanks to God in front of them all. Then he broke it and began to eat. [36] They were all encouraged and took some food themselves. [37] In all, there were 276 of us on board. [38] After the men had eaten their fill, they lightened the ship by throwing the grain into the sea. [39] When daylight came, they did not recognize the land, but they sighted a bay with a sandy beach, where they decided to run the ship aground if they could. [40] Cutting away the anchors, they left them in the sea as they loosened the ropes that held the rudders. Then they hoisted the foresail to the wind and made for the beach. [41] But the vessel struck a sandbar and ran aground. The bow stuck fast and would not move, and the stern was being broken up by the pounding of the waves. [42] The soldiers planned to kill the prisoners so none of them could swim to freedom. [43] But the centurion, wanting to spare Paul's life, thwarted their plan. He commanded those who could swim to jump overboard first and get to land. [44] The rest were to follow on planks and various parts of the ship. In this way everyone was brought safely to land.

28 Once we were safely ashore, we learned that the island was called Malta. [2] The islanders showed us extraordinary kindness. They kindled a fire and welcomed all of us because it was raining and cold. [3] Paul gathered a bundle of sticks, and as he laid them on the fire, a viper, driven out by the heat, fastened itself to his hand. [4] When the islanders saw the creature hanging from his hand, they said to one another, "Surely this man is a murderer. Although he was saved from the sea, Justice has not allowed him to live." [5] But Paul shook the creature off into the fire and suffered no ill effects. [6] The islanders were expecting him to swell up or suddenly drop dead. But after waiting a long time and seeing nothing unusual happen to him, they changed their minds and said he was a god. [7] Nearby stood an estate belonging to Publius, the chief official of the island. He welcomed us and entertained us hospitably for three days. [8] The father of Publius was sick in bed, suffering from fever and dysentery. Paul went in to see him, and after praying and placing his hands on him, he healed the man. [9] After this had happened, the rest of the sick on the island came and were cured as well.

[10] The islanders honored us in many ways and supplied our needs when we were ready to sail. [11] After three months we set sail in an Alexandrian ship that had wintered in the island. It had the Twin Brothers as a figurehead. [12] Putting in at Syracuse, we stayed there three days. [13] From there we weighed anchor and came to Rhegium. After one day, a south wind came up, and on the second day we arrived at Puteoli. [14] There we found some brothers who invited us to spend the week with them. And so we came to Rome. [15] The brothers there had heard about us and traveled as far as the Forum of Appius and the Three Taverns to meet us. When Paul saw them, he was encouraged and gave thanks to God. [16] When we arrived in Rome, Paul was permitted to stay by himself, with a soldier to guard him. [17] After three days, he called together the leaders of the Jews. When they had gathered, he said to them, "Brothers, although I have done nothing against our people or the customs of our fathers, I was taken prisoner in Jerusalem and handed over to the Romans." [18] They examined me and wanted to release me, because there was no basis for a death sentence against me. [19] But when the Jews objected, I was compelled to appeal to Caesar, even though I have no charge to bring against my nation.

[20] "So for this reason I have called to see you and speak with you. It is because of the hope of Israel that I am bound with this chain." [21] The leaders replied, "We have not received any letters about you from Judea, nor have any of the brothers from there reported or even mentioned anything bad about you." [22] "But we consider your views worth hearing, because we know that people everywhere are speaking against this sect." [23] So they set a day to meet with Paul, and many people came to the place he was staying. He expounded to them from morning to evening, testifying about the kingdom of God and persuading them about Jesus from the Law of Moses and the Prophets. [24] Some of them were convinced by what he said, but others refused to believe. [25] They disagreed among themselves and began to leave after Paul had made this final statement: "The Holy Spirit was right when He spoke to your fathers through Isaiah the prophet:" [26] 'Go to this people and say, "You will be ever hearing but never understanding; you will be ever seeing but never perceiving."' [27] For this people's heart has grown callous; they hardly hear with their ears, and they have closed their eyes. Otherwise they might see with their eyes, hear with their ears, understand with their hearts, and turn, and I would heal them.' [28] "Be advised, therefore, that God's salvation has been sent to the Gentiles, and they will listen!" [29] And when he had said these words, the Jews departed, and had great reasoning among themselves. [30] Paul stayed there two full years in his own rented house, welcoming all who came to visit him. [31] Boldly and freely he proclaimed the kingdom of God and taught about the Lord Jesus Christ.